



Boys own stuff: well-equipped teens rescue adults in jeans

Pair saved the day after group carrying a small dog got into trouble on Lake District mountain, writes **Will Humphries**

Two teenage boys practising ice climbing in the Lake District have rescued a group of adults from a snowy ridge after one of them had a panic attack.

Caelan Blades, 16, and Rowan Kay, 15, had been climbing in an ice-filled gully on Helvellyn, at 3,117ft England's third-highest mountain, when they found a distressed group of five adults dressed in trainers and jeans.

The boys, who had climbing gear including crampons and ice axes, were beginning their descent from the summit to Striding Edge, a jagged stretch of rock with sheer drops that has claimed many lives, when they came across the group stuck on the ridge on January 10.

A coastguard helicopter and air ambulance were engaged in a rescue mission on the opposite Swirral Edge, which leads off the other end of the summit, so Caelan and Rowan opted to help the group themselves. It was later

announced that a man in his seventies collapsed and died on the mountain.

Caelan, whose father, an experienced hiker, was waiting for them at the bottom of the mountain, said: "We were seeing more and more unprepared people as we came down, then Rowan pointed this group out to me ... I was extremely shocked. We couldn't believe what we were seeing. They didn't have any correct clothing or equipment."

"We were asking them, 'Do you know where you are?' and 'Do you need any water or clothing?' They didn't really understand us because they didn't speak much English. I think they were eastern European. I was watching this lady slipping around in the snow like she was on a treadmill."

Another climber told the boys he had just spent 20 minutes trying to help a woman in the group, who was carrying a dog on a leash in her arms. "He was having to help her down step by step because she was frozen up, with no gloves, no crampons, and she was having a panic attack," Caelan said.

Rowan, from Settle, North Yorkshire, said the group, who were in their late twenties, should not have been up there. The teenagers led them down the side of Striding Edge in a zig-zag pattern to Red Tarn, cutting steps for



Caelan Blades, 16, and 15-year-old Rowan Kay, top, led the stranded group, who were in their late twenties and spoke little

English, to safety down Striding Edge, a jagged stretch of rock on Helvellyn, top left, England's third-highest mountain

them in the snow as they descended.

Caelan, from Blackburn, Lancashire, said: "I wanted to save mountain rescue the trouble and give those people in most need as much resources as they



could get. I kept the lady with the dog next to me at the front and I was also under the others in case they slipped and I could stop their fall."

It took them 30 minutes to get the group back to a path they could take down to the village of Glenridding.

"They shook our hands and said 'thanks very much' and went on their way," Caelan said.

The boys came across three further groups of ill-prepared walkers attempting to climb the mountain with only 90 minutes until sunset.

"None of them had ice axes or crampons and we were warning them not to do Striding Edge," Caelan added. "Some of them said they didn't even have torches."

Caelan's mother, Deborah Blades, said she would get nervous when the two friends went off on adventures, but was "confident in their abilities".

She said: "They are sensible and genuinely good lads and the skills they

have acquired mean I am confident in them. To see what they did has just raised my confidence. Me and Rowan's mum just cried."

Caelan, who documents his outdoor adventures on TikTok, posted videos online about the rescue and was contacted by the Patterdale mountain rescue team, which invited the boys to visit its headquarters.

The rescue team said the boys showed some strong mountain skills along with maturity, adding that it was "great to see two young people, with appropriate knowledge in the outdoors, wanting to develop their skills and experience. They could be the mountain rescuers of the future".

The team said: "When seeing people in trouble, mountain rescue are here 24 hours a day, 365 days a year, to rescue those in need. [We have] the appropriate equipment and experience needed to get out in all conditions."

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